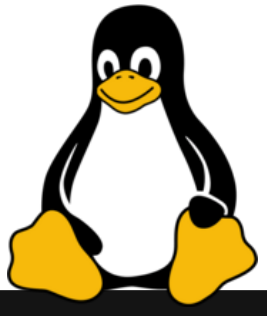
StackOne

FREE CHEAT SHEET · OCT 2026

Linux isn't hard. Here's the map.

Every top-level Linux folder on one page: what it holds, where to find things, the 3 traps that confuse beginners, and the commands to move around safely.



```
/        the root: everything starts here
├── home     your files
├── etc      settings
├── usr      installed programs
├── var      logs and changing data
├── dev      hardware as files
├── proc     live system info
└── ...      13 more inside
```

20
FOLDERS MAPPED

16
"WHERE IS IT?" ANSWERS

14
SAFE COMMANDS

FOLLOW @STACKONE.TECH FOR DAILY TECH IN 60 SECONDS

STACKONETECH.COM

One tree. No drive letters.

Windows gives every disk a letter (C:, D:). Linux has one tree that starts at /. Disks and USB drives are attached ("mounted") somewhere inside it.

Your stuff

/home	One folder per user: documents, downloads, settings. `/home/yohan = ~`
/root	Home folder of the admin user (root). Not the top of the tree.

Settings

/etc	System-wide config files, all plain text. `/etc/ssh, /etc/nginx, /etc/hostname`

Programs

/usr	Installed programs, libraries and docs. `/usr/bin, /usr/lib, /usr/share`
/bin	Everyday commands: ls, cp, cat. Often a link to /usr/bin.
/sbin	Admin commands: reboot, fdisk. Often a link to /usr/sbin.
/lib	Shared libraries those commands need. Often a link to /usr/lib.
/opt	Big add-on apps installed as one folder.

Changing data

/var	Data that grows and changes. `/var/log, /var/cache, /var/lib`
/tmp	Temporary files. Can be wiped on reboot.
/run	Runtime info since the last boot (sockets, PIDs).
/srv	Data this machine serves (sites, FTP), on some setups.

Hardware and live system

/dev	Devices as files. `/dev/sda, /dev/nvme0n1, /dev/null`
/proc	Not real files: live process and kernel info. `/proc/cpuinfo`
/sys	Not real files: live device and driver info.

Start-up and drives

/boot	Kernel and bootloader files that start the system.
/media	USB drives and discs appear here automatically.
/mnt	Where you attach a drive by hand, for a while.
/lost+found	Pieces recovered after a disk check.

Path basics

`/etc/ssh`	**Absolute path:** starts with /, works from anywhere.
`logs/app.log`	**Relative path:** starts from the folder you're in now.
`~`	Your home folder (/home/you).
`. and ..`	This folder, and the folder one level up.

Where do I find...?

Common paths on Ubuntu and Debian. Other distros are close, but check with the commands on page 4.

I'M LOOKING FOR	LOOK HERE
My own files	`~ (same as /home/you)`
System logs	`/var/log · or run journalctl`
SSH server settings	`/etc/ssh/sshd_config`
Nginx or Apache config	`/etc/nginx · /etc/apache2`
Website files	`/var/www`
List of user accounts	`/etc/passwd`
Hostname and DNS servers	`/etc/hostname · /etc/resolv.conf`
Scheduled jobs (cron)	`/etc/crontab · crontab -l`
Docker images and volumes	`/var/lib/docker`
A USB drive I plugged in	`/media/you/DRIVE-NAME`
Disks and partitions	`/dev/sda1 · /dev/nvme0n1p1 · lsblk`
CPU and memory info	`/proc/cpuinfo · /proc/meminfo`
Where a command lives	`which nginx`
Software I installed by hand	`/usr/local · /opt`
Hidden app settings	`~/.config · ~/.bashrc`
Kernel files	`/boot/vmlinuz-*`

The 3 traps

`/ vs /root`
"Root" means two things. / is the top of the tree. /root is only the admin's home folder.

`/usr is not "user"`
Your files are in /home. /usr holds installed programs and libraries.

`Dot = hidden`
Files starting with a dot (.bashrc) are hidden. Use ls -a to see them.

14 commands to find your way

Where am I and what's here?

`pwd`	Show the folder you're in now.
`ls -la`	List everything, including hidden files, with sizes and owners.
`cd /etc`	Go to a folder with its full path (starts with /).
`cd ~`	Go to your home folder.
`cd ..`	Go up one level.
`cd -`	Go back to the previous folder.

Find things

`find / -name "*.conf" 2>/dev/null`	Search the whole tree by name and hide permission errors.
`which python3`	Show where a command's program lives.
`less /var/log/syslog`	Read a long file page by page (q to quit).
`man hier`	The built-in manual for this folder layout.

Space and disks

`df -h`	Free space on each disk.
`du -sh *`	Size of each item in this folder.
`lsblk`	Disks and partitions as a tree.
`sudo journalctl --vacuum-time=7d`	Shrink old system logs to the last 7 days.

Never delete

- /boot, /etc, /usr, /bin, /lib: the system stops working.
- /dev, /proc, /sys: they're live, not real files.
- Never run `rm -rf /` or paste rm commands you don't understand.

Safe habits

- Copy a config before editing: cp file file.bak
- Use sudo only when a command needs it.
- Clear space with ~/.cache, old downloads and the log command above.

Tech explained in 60 seconds, every day.

AI, software, gadgets and the internet, explained simply with motion graphics.
Follow StackOne so you never miss a free guide.

Instagram
@stackone.tech

TikTok
@stackone.tech

YouTube
@stackonetech

Facebook
StackOne Tech

stackonetech.com
WEB · APPS · AI PRODUCTS · BUILT IN SRI LANKA

VISIT →

Want the next free guide?

COMMENT "PDF" ON OUR VIDEOS

© 2026 STACKONE TECH · SHARE THIS PDF FREELY, DON'T SELL IT